

started, the national team was overwhelmingly dependent on players from Manipur, the State across the border from Myanmar, where a related traditional game has long been played. The current squad still has a strong Manipuri presence. Malemnganba Singh Sorokhaibam, who plays as a feeder — players who block strikes and set up shots — is from Manipur, as is Lokhon Singh, who plays as a striker.

Meanwhile, Bobby brings Bihar into the mix, while Delhi is represented by feeders Arun Kumar and Ram Kumar. From Assam comes Amarjit Singha, another feeder adding to the growing pool of talent.

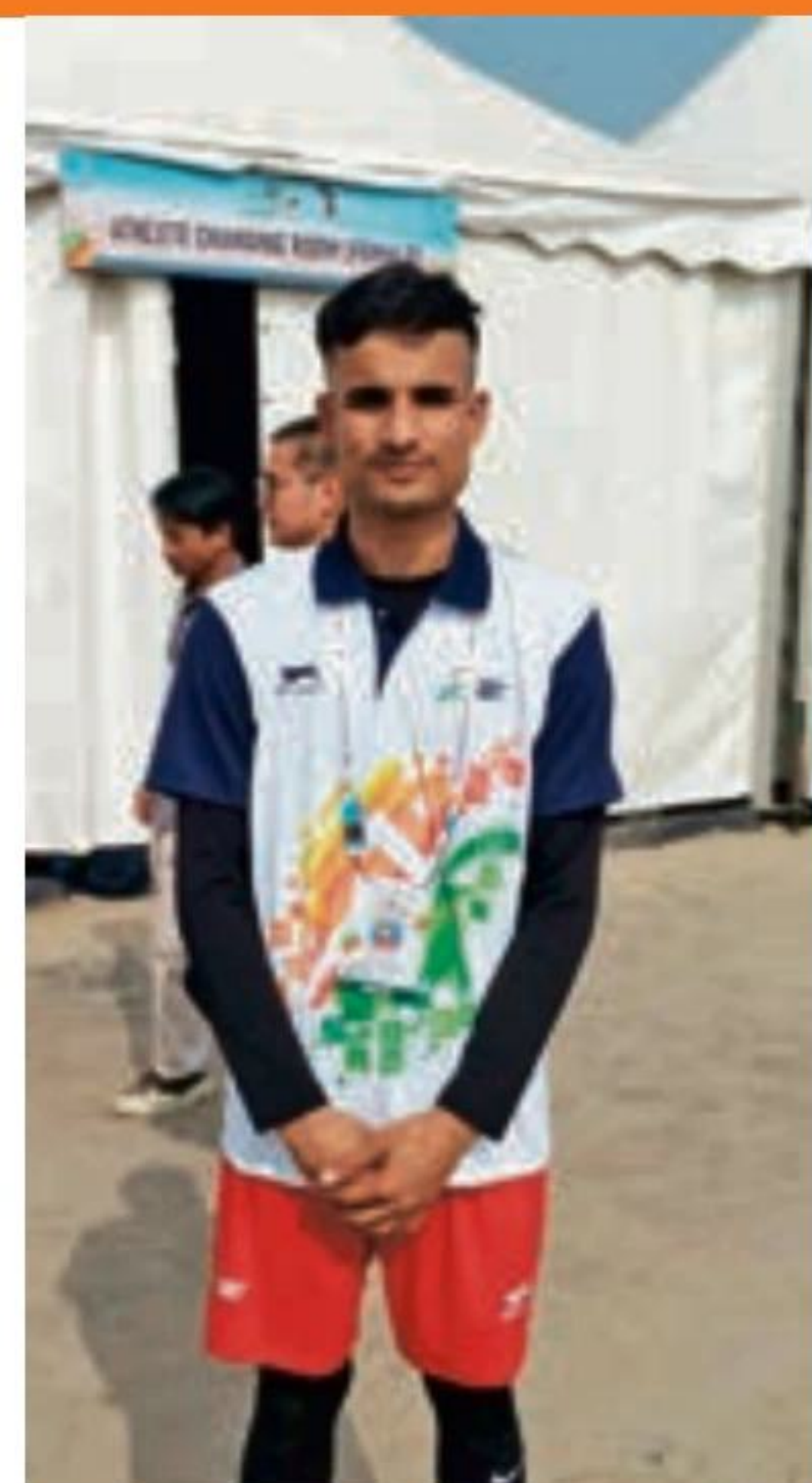
Bobby's own story illustrates that change. Bobby first encountered sepak takraw in a park near his home in Patna, Bihar, in 2015. He had been playing cricket and football when he saw people playing the unfamiliar sport. He tried it barefoot and was hooked.

In 2019, he took the bigger gamble of moving to the Sports Authority of India (SAI) centre in Bareilly, a city in the Northern State of Uttar Pradesh, against the wishes of his father, a former footballer. "At that time my only dream was that I'd one day play for India — I thought that I would play in India," he says. "It's a dream. I will fulfil my dream."

Seven years later, he is part of the senior national team and headed to his first Asian Games. His goal is the same as Akash's. "We want to stand on the podium. We know we can," he says. While Bobby doesn't have much experience with failure, Akash does. At the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou, India men finished seventh in both events, regu and quad, in which Akash competed.

"I felt I had let the team down," he says. But there was also a tactical reason. Competing in the quad, India had been playing with one striker. Opponents had learned how to block that attack. Akash remembers being blocked repeatedly and struggling to find a way through.

The team going to Aichi-Nagoya has embraced a two-striker system. Arun explains the thinking. "For a long time, no one thought of playing two



Parallel paths and modest beginnings: Tondonba Singh (#6), who hails from Akash Yumnam's village in Manipur, followed the footballing path Akash once considered. He currently plays for NorthEast United. **Right:** Bobby Kumar, one of India's emerging sepak takraw players, took up the sport after spotting a game in a park near his home in Patna. From playing barefoot there, he has gone on to the senior national team and his first Asian Games. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & ADITYA PADINJAT

strikers in sepak takraw. But at the last Asian Games, the Philippines played with two strikers. So you have multiple chances of making attacks. They ended up winning medals in both the regu and quad events. So we got an idea from them," he says.

India's defence has also changed. Previously, the team relied heavily on foot blocks. Now its players are using the waist as well. "Our blocking is amongst the best in the world right now," Arun says.

Although India is competing in the team regu as well, Arun believes its best chance is in the quad event. The latter format has four players on court, rather than the three used in regu. If India has to challenge the dominance of the traditional Southeast Asian powers in this sport, which traces its roots to Malaysia and Thailand, Akash will have to play a major role.

There's reason to believe this is possible. In February this year, the Indian team beat Thailand, Malaysia, South Korea and Japan to win gold in the quad event at the Asian Sepak Takraw Championship in Nagoya, the official test event for these Asian Games.

It is a more tactically flexible Indian team than the one that went to

Hangzhou. It has already tested and proved itself against the best. Still, there is no complacency.

Akash knows better. "In the league, everyone is tough," he says. "Myanmar, Vietnam, Laos — they play well. We have to beat at least two of them if we want to make it to the semifinals. We will not win easily, but we are confident that we will do well," he says.

Indian contingent



Men

Arun, Jasvir, Ashish Chundawat, Shyam Singh, Lokhon Singh Elangbam, Bobby Kumar, Ashok Singh Mayengbam, Ram Kumar Sharma, O Amarjit Singha, Malemnganba Singh Sorokhaibam, Henary Singh Wahengbam, Akash Yumnam

Women

Leirentonbi Devi Elangbam, Prity Langoljam, Menenu Tsukru, Maipak Devi Ayekpam, Priya Devi Elangbam, Shilpa Elangbam, Chaoba Devi Oinam, Seyiekhrieno Tapa, Malemnganbi Yumnam